title—from an insult to a badge of pride. The process of coming out to family was eventually a non-issue: first, to his siblings as a young fashion student, and, much later, to his mother, a woman he venerates and adores. "It was a huge relief," he says. "There is freedom in telling the truth. In our culture, family is everything. There is immense love, but also expectation. Coming out meant risking disappointment."

Gurung has a clear and confident voice throughout and does not hesitate to take on thorny subjects or his own flaws. The memoir also doubles up as a searing insider account of the fashion world—a world of glamour and creativity, but also beset by racism, body image issues and cut-throat competitiveness. The highs can be extraordinarily dizzying, and the lows sapping. "Sometimes, the hardest thing was simply believing I deserved to be in the room," he says. "There were professional setbacks that felt devastating. There were moments of financial strain. There were seasons when the fashion industry felt unforgiving. And there were personal moments, quiet, interior battles that no one saw." He repeatedly attributes his perseverance and strength to his mother and sister.

Gurung writes of having achieved most of what he had hoped for at the outset. Now, he has set his sights on building institutions, "not just collections", expanding his philanthropic work and mentoring a new generation of designers. "Creatively, I still feel hungry," he says. "There are films to produce, stories to tell, silhouettes to create, and new languages of design to explore." ■

—Bhavya Dore

What Lies Beneath

SHEFALEE VASUDEV'S *STORIES WE WEAR* EXAMINES SOCIETY AND CULTURE THROUGH THE PRISM OF CLOTHING

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'That's how I think about clothes, as tools of appearance. They are never simply "fashion-fashion".' Vasudev's postscript, written recently for the *Voice of Fashion*, the digital magazine she edits, sets an ambitious frame for her book. Rightly so. The book satisfactorily breaks apart many assumptions, from that of what a fashion journalist can, and will, write (though Vasudev's long and illustrious portfolio far exceeds fashion) to what breadth or depth of content can fit within the scope of a story about clothes. It is a truly political framing. It changes the way you look at familiar places, people and practices.

Each chapter takes a space—the airport, a cremation ground, the Instagram feed of an influencer, a public walkway, a coffee shop, the industry around a single fabric—and zooms in on protagonists and patterns there that you pay little heed to. Those, then, become the key informants that illuminate the power play, the economies at work, the constant work of narrative-building that makes these spaces what they are. In refusing to stay with the known narrative, Vasudev brings reporting skills to change the story itself, and unsettles it from the clear and obvious. 'Appearance' is kaleidoscopic, charged with multiple shards of identity, circumstance and desire.

In 'The Airport Look', for instance, you look, for the first time, with depth and empathy at the CISF officers, who are generally a source of friction in getting where you need to at the pace you need to. In 'Bareilly ki Barfi', Vasudev delves into a space quite familiar—female agency and rebellion—but her protagonists sit along a wide spectrum, from OTT 'anti-heroines' to sportspersons, photographers, home-based influencers, domestic workers who shape-shift. Vasudev diligently resists fixing and 'understanding' them, assigning either bravery or submission as character traits.

Similarly, in 'Masaba: Lovechild of the Instagram Era', there is a resistance to seeing the storied designer-actor-influencer in a way that must agree or disagree with, or judge her trajectory and choices, instead only witnessing—and reporting—the arc of how she navigates the shifting digital landscape. It feels liberating and enlightening, this broader, less dogmatic lens.

Chapters and the narrative itself sometimes feel circular and repetitive and could have been more tightly edited. But with some discounting for length and slight overwriting, this is a timely must-read for anyone interested in probing the appearances of our familiar worlds. ■

—Disha Mullick

STORIES WE WEAR
Status, Spectacle and the Politics of Appearance
By Shefalee Vasudev
WESTLAND
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